

Digital connectivity has the potential to deliver transformative economic empowerment, according to Minister of Communications and Digital Technologies, Solly Malatsi.

Malatsi said this will allow South Africans to learn new skills and expand access to economic opportunities.

To this end, the future of the digital economy and AI innovation will unfold at the G20 Leaders' Summit in Johannesburg in November.

The summit takes place amid global challenges including climate change with its impacts like extreme weather and food insecurity, economic instability such as inflation and poverty, health crises including pandemics, growing income inequality and societal polarisation, and threats from conflict, emerging technologies, and the erosion of truth and democracy.

Solutions

Digital economies and innovation are expected to offer solutions by increasing access to essential services such as education and healthcare, fostering sustainable development through optimised resource management, creating new job opportunities and economic growth, and improving global connectivity and collaboration.

Technologies such as broadband internet, AI and digital payments enable remote work, precision agriculture, and efficient e-government services, contributing to poverty reduction, environmental sustainability, and enhanced productivity.

Malatsi, speaking to Independent Media ahead of the summit, outlined four strategic focus areas under South Africa's G20 Digital Economy Presidency: connectivity, digital public infrastructure (DPI), innovation ecosystems for MSMEs, and ethical artificial intelligence (AI).

He said the government's vision is to build a dynamic, inclusive and globally competitive digital economy that empowers citizens and unlocks opportunities for businesses of all sizes.

The government is committed to enabling this future through progressive policies, meaningful connectivity for all, public-private partnerships, digital infrastructure investment, and reskilling and upskilling the workforce for the digital age.

Connection

"Digital inclusion is a top priority. We have launched initiatives such as SA Connect and Connect Mzansi, focused on extending broadband to underserved communities, schools, clinics and public institutions. We are also expanding access to devices and digital literacy through partnerships with entities and the private sector.

"Digital inclusion is not just about access; it is about meaningful connectivity and participation in the economy and society.

"We aim to create a conducive environment for policies that attract investments and promote competition, starting with a comprehensive review of legislation regulating the ICT sector," Malatsi said.

Recovery

Indonesia's 2022 summit stressed the importance of digital connectivity and post-pandemic recovery under the theme "Recover Together, Recover Stronger," focusing on inclusive transformation and digital literacy.

India's 2023 presidency promoted digital public infrastructure as a global good, launching a Global Digital Public Infrastructure Repository to share open technological solutions and knowledge worldwide.

Brazil, in 2024, focused on digital inclusion,